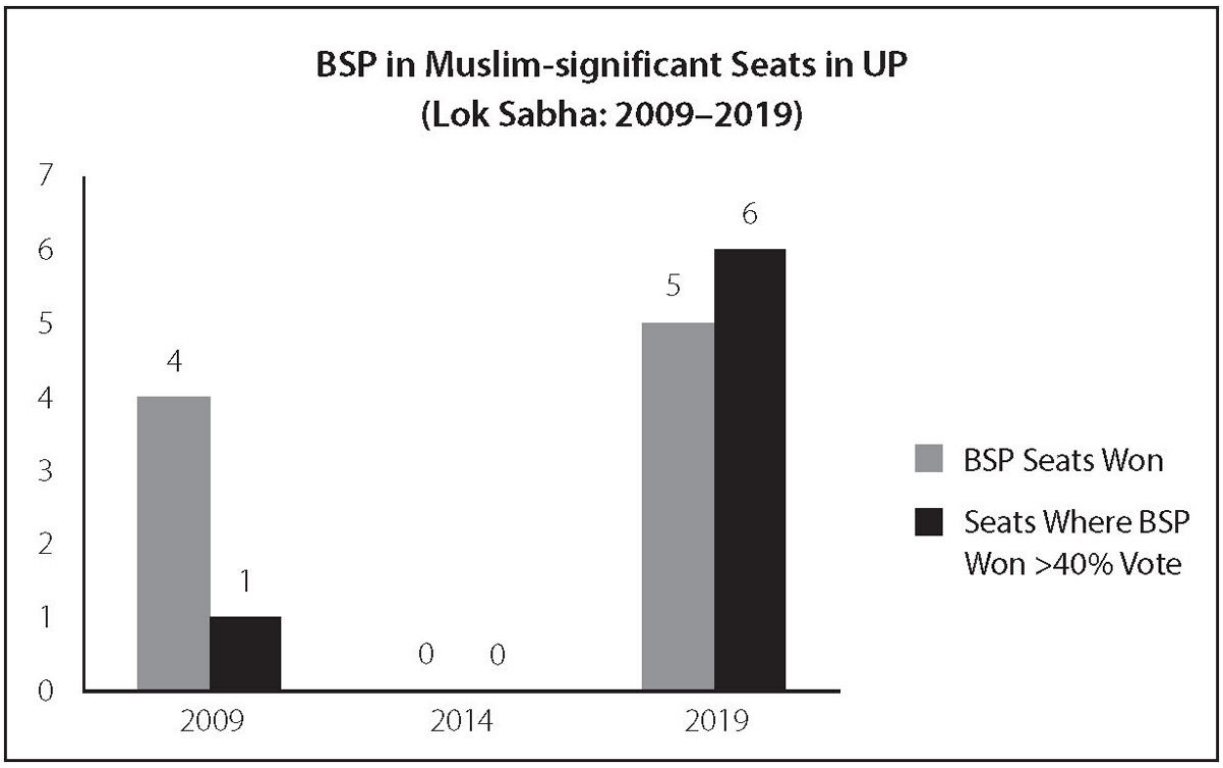


Source: ECI data. Analysis by Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava, PollNiti. We are thankful to Jai Mrug for classification of seats with 30 per cent or more Muslim voters.

In other words, while other parties mostly fielded Muslim candidates in these seats, hoping to attract what they saw as a monolithic chunk of Muslim voters, the community's vote often ended up being split between them. The BJP, on the other hand, always fielded a Hindu candidate in such seats. It benefited from a consolidation of Hindu voters in response to a perceived Muslim political mobilisation, which had the potential to override other issues of difference among them. With the Muslim vote divided between rival candidates, the BJP often needed a lower winning threshold in Muslim-significant seats. The party won fewer Muslim-significant seats in 2019 even though it attracted more votes than earlier because of the SP–BSP alliance against it. Yet, the alliance also resulted in a sharper polarisation among voters along Hindu–Muslim lines. Again, like in the wider Hindi heartland, the Congress went from being a strong force in UP in 2009 (four seats, 17.7 per cent votes) to zero seats in 2019. This pattern of the rise of the BJP and